

Isekai Strategem: Complete Game Design Document

What this is. A single, plain-language explanation of the entire game as it exists on the `main` branch. It is written to be read start to finish by someone who has never seen the game before. Every system is explained in normal English, every number that matters is given, and every piece of content (each Trigger, each Black Trigger ability, each status effect, each perk, each counter, each unique ability, each combo) is described so you know exactly what it does.

This is the single source of truth for how the game works. If a rule is not in here, it is not documented anywhere else. (`docs/current_development_status.md` tracks what is done, in progress, and planned, plus the combat-rework design detail.)

The short version. Isekai Strategem is a turn-based fighting game where you build a team of three characters, give each one a set of abilities, and battle another team of three until one side is wiped out. Its ideas come from three places: the anime/manga World Trigger (the words Trion, Trigger, Black Trigger, and the Attacker / Shooter / Sniper / Trapper roles), Naruto (energy-style resource play and status effects like genjutsu, shadow-binding, and sealing), and tabletop Dungeons and Dragons (rolling a 20-sided die to hit, rolling with advantage or disadvantage, critical hits, and a big list of status conditions).

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1. What the game is, in one page

You control a **squad of three characters**. So does your opponent (usually an AI). Each of your characters carries a **Loadout**, which is a small set of **Triggers** (abilities) plus, optionally, one powerful **Black Trigger**.

A battle is a series of **turns** that alternate between the two squads. On your turn you pick actions for your living characters, choose their targets, and end the turn. Your actions then play out, the enemy takes its turn, and this repeats until every character on one side has been reduced to 0 Health. Reducing a character to 0 Health takes it out of the fight for good ("DEFEATED"), and a strong hit can do that in one blow, so the game is about smart planning: managing your resource, landing status effects at the right moment, setting traps for the enemy, and building a team whose pieces support each other. It is not about simply having bigger numbers.

There is also an unfinished story mode (visual-novel style). This document is about the battle game.

2. The moment-to-moment loop

Here is what you actually do, in order, every time you play:

1. **Pick your three characters.** Each has fixed starting stats, a type (Attack, Defense, Support, or Unique), and one built-in perk that is always on.
 2. **Build each character's Loadout.** You equip Triggers into their slots. Every Trigger has an equip cost, and the total must fit inside that character's Trion Capacity. You must end up with exactly four usable abilities (more on the rules in the Loadouts section).
 3. **The game grades your team.** Before the fight, it looks at your three Loadouts and gives your squad a **Team Efficiency Grade** (a letter grade from D up to SSS). A higher grade helps you in the fight but earns you less XP afterward, and a lower grade is the reverse. This is a deliberate risk-reward trade.
 4. **Fight.** Turns alternate. On your turn you queue up actions and end the turn; they resolve in a set order, then the AI responds.
 5. **Win or lose, then get XP.** When one squad is wiped out, the winner is decided and the player earns XP based on the inverse of their grade.
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3. Your team: characters and the four types

A squad is always **exactly three characters**, chosen from a roster of **20**. Every character belongs to one of four **types**, and the type tells you their job and the general shape of their stats. (The exact stats for all 20 characters are in Appendix B.)

- **Attack (5 characters).** Front-line damage dealers. High Attack (10 to 13), low Defense, and low Team Spirit, which as you will see leans them toward hitting hard. These are your glass cannons.
- **Defense (5 characters).** Tanks. High Defense (10 to 12) and higher Armor, so they soak hits and hold the line. They also carry more control tools.

- **Support (5 characters).** Healers and enablers. High Trion Affinity (so they fuel the team's resource) and high Team Spirit (so they lean toward sustaining the team), with low Attack. They keep everyone alive and topped up.
- **Unique (5 characters).** Specialists. Each is built around one signature "unique" ability and a distinctive perk, so they do something no plain character can.

Your choice of types also feeds the Team Efficiency Grade: a team whose stats and abilities all pull in the same clear direction scores better than a muddled one.

4. Stats: what each number means

Every character has a block of stats. All of them are shown in the game (the loadout and roster screens display even the ones that used to be hidden). Here is what each one actually does in plain terms:

- **Attack.** Added to your 20-sided die roll when you try to hit someone. Higher Attack means you land hits more often. It is the biggest factor in whether an attack connects.
 - **Defense.** Added to the defender's die roll when they are attacked. Higher Defense means enemies miss you more often.
 - **Armor.** A flat amount of damage removed from every hit that lands on you, after all the multipliers. Small but constant protection.
 - **Max Health.** How much damage you can take before you are knocked out. Every character starts at 100. At 0 Health, the character is DEFEATED and gone.
 - **Trion Capacity.** Two things at once: the size of your spendable resource pool, and the budget you have for equipping Triggers when you build the Loadout. It ranges from about 100 to 130 across the roster.
 - **Trion Affinity.** Improves the odds that you gain a larger amount of Trion at the start of each turn. A high-Affinity character is your team's battery.
 - **Team Spirit.** A slider from 0 to 100 (explained in the next section). Below 50 it makes you more offensive, above 50 it makes you better at sustaining.
 - **Critical Chance.** The chance that an attack becomes a critical hit, which rolls the ability's damage dice a second time. Mechanically, more Critical Chance widens the range of dice rolls that count as a crit, down to a natural 17 at the very most.
 - **FAT Chance.** The chance that Full Arms Trigger activates on your turn, which lets that character use up to three abilities in one turn instead of one.
 - **Status Infliction.** How good you are at making your status effects stick when you try to apply them. Think of it as the strength of your attempt.
 - **Status Resistance.** How good you are at shrugging off status effects that others try to put on you. Think of it as your saving throw.
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5. Team Spirit: the offense-or-sustain slider

Team Spirit is a single number from 0 to 100, where **50 is neutral**. It pulls in two opposite directions depending on which side of 50 you are on:

- **Below 50 leans offensive.** The lower you go, the bigger the bonus. At the extreme (Team Spirit 0) you get up to +30% damage on single-target attacks, +30% damage on burst attacks, and +20 Critical Chance.

- **Above 50 leans sustaining.** The higher you go, the bigger the bonus. At the extreme (Team Spirit 100) you get up to +30% to healing you receive and +20 FAT Chance.
- **At exactly 50** you get nothing either way.

So an Attack character sitting around 30 to 40 Team Spirit is a committed glass cannon (extra damage and crits), while a Support around 60 to 70 is a committed sustainer (better healing and more frequent burst turns). The game shows a live readout next to the value telling you which way it currently leans and by how much. Because committing hard to one pole is rewarded, Team Spirit is one of the biggest inputs into your Team Efficiency Grade.

6. Trion: the resource you spend

Trion is the energy you spend to use abilities. It comes in two connected forms:

- **Trion Capacity** is your pool size and also your Loadout building budget. Every Trigger has two costs: an **equip cost** (paid once against your Capacity when you build the team) and a **Trion cost** (paid from your running pool each time you use it in battle).
- **Per-turn income.** At the start of each of your turns, your side rolls for how much Trion it gains that turn. There are three tiers:

Tier	You gain	How it is rolled
Low	+10	The starting state every turn.
Medium	+20	You have a 35% base chance to upgrade Low to Medium, plus 1% for each point of your squad's total Trion Affinity.
High	+35	If you reached Medium, you roll again to reach High: a 20% base chance plus 1% per point of total Trion Affinity.

So the more Trion Affinity your squad has, the more often you gain the bigger amounts. A high-Affinity Support like Haru Ellison (Affinity 32) noticeably raises the whole team's income.

Attacking the enemy's Trion is a real strategy. Several status effects target it: Sapped drains a quarter of the target's Trion Capacity, Genjutsu Trapped drains 15% of it (and stops them acting), Silenced stops them using abilities at all, Overcharged halves your ability costs, and Choked doubles the target's costs.

Design note: right now income is a semi-random roll and most turns you only cast one ability, so your Capacity rarely runs dry. A future balance pass may make income steadier and tie your big burst turns to your Capacity.

7. Triggers and Loadouts: building an ability set

A **Trigger** is a single ability. A **Loadout** is one character's chosen set of Triggers, plus optionally one Black Trigger. Building good Loadouts is the main puzzle before the fight.

The rules you must follow when building a Loadout:

- You may equip at most **8 items** total (Triggers and the Black Trigger all count together toward this 8).

- You must have **exactly 4 active abilities** (an active Trigger counts as 1, and a Black Trigger contributes however many active abilities it carries).
- The **total equip cost cannot exceed** that character's Trion Capacity.

So it is a packing puzzle: fit exactly four usable abilities, plus any passive Triggers you want (counters, stat boosts), all inside the Trion budget. Passive Triggers do not attack; they sit in your slots and do things automatically, like firing a counter or granting a stat.

What defines a Trigger. Each active Trigger carries a name, an equip cost, a Trion cost, a cooldown in turns, how much damage it rolls, how many targets it can hit, how many separate hits it makes, an optional heal, any status effects it applies, and sometimes a special unique or counter behavior. On top of that it carries five **tags** that decide how it behaves and what can interact with it: its category, its attack type, its attack subtype, its range, and its origin. Those five are worth understanding properly, because most of the game's interactions key off them.

Category: what job the Trigger does

The 60 active Triggers are grouped into five **categories** by their role, which line up with World Trigger's classes:

- **Attacker (16):** melee bruisers who close in and hit hard.
- **Shooter (9):** ranged fighters who fire volume, often in bursts.
- **Sniper (3):** long-range specialists who land one big shot.
- **Trapper (24):** control, damage-over-time, debuffs, and most of the unique abilities.
- **Optional (8):** buffs, wards, self-help, and the reactive counters.

Attack type: melee, ranged, or psychic

Every active Trigger is one of three **attack types**, and the catalog is deliberately balanced to exactly 20 of each:

- **Melee (20):** physical attacks made up close. Blades, fists, impact.
- **Ranged (20):** attacks made at a distance. Shots, grenades, thrown effects.
- **Psychic (20):** attacks on the mind rather than the body. Fear, silence, illusion, and most of the strangest abilities in the game.

Psychic is its own type rather than a flavor of ranged, because it is the type that carries the mind-affecting statuses and the bulk of the unique abilities.

Attack subtype: how the attack lands

The **subtype** is what actually decides how an attack resolves:

- **Single (20 Triggers):** one target, one to-hit roll, one damage roll.
- **Area, or AOE (15):** hits several targets at once (usually up to 3). Each target gets its own to-hit roll and its own damage roll, so an area attack can land on one enemy and miss another. Area attacks also **bypass** the counters that only catch single-target attacks, like Mirror Ward.
- **Burst (8):** several separate hits, each rolled independently. Careful here: the hit count is **per target**, not shared out among them. Suppressing Fire hits 3 times against *each* of up to 2 targets, so it makes 6 rolls in total. Every hit rolls to-hit and damage on its own, which means Armor is subtracted from each hit separately and a burst is weak against heavily armored targets.

- **Unique (17):** a bespoke ability that writes its own rules. These do not follow the standard hit-and-damage flow at all. See section 14.

Not every combination exists. Melee has no bursts, and psychic has no bursts either, so the distribution across the 60 Triggers looks like this:

Attack type	Single	Area	Burst	Unique	Total
Melee	10	5	0	5	20
Ranged	5	5	8	2	20
Psychic	5	5	0	10	20
Total	20	15	8	17	60

Range band: how far away it works

Separately from its attack type, each Trigger sits in one of three **range bands**, 20 Triggers each:

- **Close Range (20):** you have to be right there. Contact work.
- **Mid Range (20):** the middle distance. You can see them clearly and reach them, but you are not on top of each other.
- **Long Range (20):** across the field.

These bands are not the same thing as the attack type, and the names are deliberately different so the two do not get mixed up. Attack type answers *what kind of attack is this*; the band answers *how far away can you be when you use it*. Those are genuinely independent questions, and **every attack type appears in every band**:

Attack type	Close	Mid	Long	Total
Melee	12	5	3	20
Ranged	3	8	9	20
Psychic	5	7	8	20
Total	20	20	20	60

The interesting entries are the ones that break the obvious pattern:

- **Melee at Long Range.** Piercing Thrust is a committed lunge that crosses the gap to land, so you start it from a distance even though it ends with a blade in someone. Rally Cry is a shout, and a shout carries across the field. Martyr's End is a detonation that reaches every enemy there is.
- **Ranged at Close Range.** Scattershot is a scattergun: devastating point-blank and useless at any distance. Pepper Shot and Venom Spray are the same idea, a spread with no carry.
- **Psychic at Close Range.** Charm Whisper only works at whispering distance. Soul Siphon needs a hand on them, Memory Theft needs to reach into a mind you are touching, Karmic Bind needs contact to tie the knot, and Sensory Swap needs hold of both people at once.

The band matters because several effects only touch attacks made **at a distance**, which means Mid and Long together. Threatened and Blinded penalize those attack rolls and leave Close Range alone, Blinded also cuts how many targets they can reach, and Frozen Tempo sabotages

the cooldowns of anyone who attacks its holder from range. So a Close Range build is quietly resistant to a whole family of debuffs, and that is now a real reason to take a point-blank scattergun over a rifle.

Position: where each character is standing

The bands are not just labels on abilities. Each character occupies a **position** on the battlefield, and the band decides what they can reach from there.

- Every character stands at **Front, Middle or Back**, worth 0, 1 and 2. Their starting position comes from the bands their own Loadout carries: a Close Range kit starts at the Front, a sniper's kit at the Back.
- **Distance to an enemy is the two positions added, plus screening**, because the squads face each other across a gap and their squad stands in the way. See below.
- **Distance to an ally is the two positions subtracted**, because you are on the same side. Your Front and your own Back are 2 apart. Screening never applies: your own squad is not in the way of a heal.
- An ability works if the distance falls inside its band's window: **Close reaches 0 to 2, Mid reaches 1 to 3, Long reaches 2 to 4.**

The minimums are the important half. A sniper caught in a scrum at distance 0 or 1 genuinely has no shot, which is what stops standing at the back being free. Against an ally only a maximum applies, since needing room to bring a weapon to bear has nothing to do with handing a heal to the person beside you, and there the Close Range maximum is **1** rather than 2: a Close Range ward reaches the next line along, not the whole formation.

Screening: the bodies in the way. To the two lines added, add the number of **living members of the target's own squad standing on a line strictly in front of them**. That is the whole rule, and it does most of the work in this section.

- Screening is a property of the **line**, not of the character. Everyone standing together has the same number of bodies in front of them, so the battlefield strip prints one distance per enemy line and marks each screened enemy with a pip per body shielding them.
- A sniper behind two squadmates sits at effective distance 4 and only Long Range reaches them. Kill one screen and Mid Range opens up. Kill both and Close Range arrives.
Breaking a screen is how you reach the people behind it, and that is the tactical loop the whole rule exists to create.
- **A squad stacked on one line screens nobody**, because nobody is standing in front of anybody. So camping at the back stops working of its own accord rather than having to be taxed.
- **The frontmost character always has zero screens**, so no squad can ever make itself unreachable. The bodies doing the screening are themselves the easiest thing on the board to hit.

You are at	Their Front	Their Middle	Their Back
Front	0, Close only	1, Close or Mid	2, any band
Middle	1, Close or Mid	2, any band	3, Mid or Long
Back	2, any band	3, Mid or Long	4, Long only

That table is the **unscreened** case: it assumes nobody is standing in front of the target, which is true of a squad stacked on one line and of every frontmost character. Add one to the number for each body in the way.

At **distance 0**, both squads crowded onto their front lines, only Close Range works, because Mid and Long both have minimums. At **distance 4**, both squads hanging back, only Long Range works, and a fight that settles there stops being a fight. **Distance 2 is the one every band covers**, which makes it the most contested square on the board.

Screening can push the number as high as **6**, which no band reaches at all. That is not a trap: measured from your **own front line** the distance never exceeds 4 whatever the enemy formation, so a character who can walk forward always has a shot eventually. A 5 or a 6 on the ruler means you chose to stand too far back, and the answer is to move up.

Moving. Reposition shifts a character one step and costs them their ability use for that turn, so closing the gap competes with attacking. It costs no Trion. A FAT turn, which grants up to three actions, is therefore the turn you can move *and* strike. A character can always Reposition even when nothing else is legal, so a bad position costs you tempo but never your whole turn. A zone-lock effect (Forced Repetition) is the exception: it pins you where you stand.

You plan against where you will be, not where you are. Moves resolve before every ability in the turn, in the arm phase (section 8). So the moment you queue a step, the whole turn is judged from the destination: abilities that were out of band light up, abilities that needed the old distance go dark, and the target picker offers exactly what the new line can reach. Un-queueing the step takes the strikes that depended on it back out of the queue and refunds them, rather than letting them resolve into thin air.

The battlefield strip under both squads draws this: your back line on the far left through to the opponent's back line on the far right, with the two front lines meeting in the middle, so the gap you see is the distance the bands are measured in. It prints the effective distance to each enemy line under the enemy half, screens included, because that is the number the bands are compared against; it marks a screened enemy with a pip per body shielding them, so who you have to kill to get closer is readable without counting lines; it shades the lines the selected ability reaches; and its own cells are the move control, so position is read and changed in one place.

That is what makes the four questions the pillar was built for answerable at the moment of decision rather than a turn late:

- *Am I in range to do this?* The ability is lit or it is dark, and a dark one says which band it needs, what distance that band covers, and whether it is their squad screening the target that put it out of reach.
- *Am I in their attack range?* The lane diagram stacks both squads, your back line at the top and theirs at the bottom, so the gap on screen is the distance the bands are measured in.
- *Am I in range to receive buffs and healing?* Ally range uses only the maximum, so it is the spread of your own squad that decides, and the diagram shows it.
- *Will they be in range of my trap in two turns?* The trap keeps its band and the line it was armed from, so the bet is readable off the same picture.

Every ability says why it cannot be used. Out of range names the band and the distance it covers, and when screening is what put the target out of reach it says so and names the fix, because breaking a screen and moving are different answers to the same red text. The case a moving character meets constantly gets its own treatment: without a Full Arms Trigger the step

spends the turn's only action, so an ability the move has just brought into band pulses rather than going flat, and says so when tapped. That distinguishes the three reasons an ability is dark, which are fixed in three different ways: move, wait for the cooldown, or take a FAT turn.

The opponent plays the same board. The AI aims only at what its bands actually reach, and it moves on two rules: a character who can reach nothing steps towards the band it needs, and a character with an ability use to spare spends one on the step that brings more of its Loadout to bear. A character with one action and something worth doing keeps the action, because paying a whole turn to improve the next one is a bad trade.

Area attacks catch a position, not a squad. An area ability hits everyone standing with the target you aimed at, and nobody standing elsewhere. Bunching your squad together makes you a target; spreading out is a genuine defence.

Traps remember where they were laid. A trap records the position it was armed from and its own band, and only fires if the enemy is inside that band when they act. Setting one is a bet on where they will be standing for as long as it lasts. How long that is is a per-ability number, and those numbers are unpriced first-pass values awaiting the SPTV pass (see below).

A trap is the one thing screening does not block. It is already attached to its target, and squadmates shuffling about in front of them does not unstick it. The two lines still count, so an enemy who falls back out of the band you armed from does escape it, and so do you if you retreat. Every trap you place on an enemy asks that question.

Some things need you to be close. Root Snare pins its target in place as well as locking their ability, so a Trapper decides where the fight happens. Sable's Guardian's Instinct only intercepts an attack on someone he is standing with or next to, because a bodyguard has to actually be there.

Design note: the band used to be a two-value near/far tag, and every non-melee Trigger was lumped into "ranged", which made it perfectly predictable from the attack type and therefore empty of information. It became three bands assigned per ability, and then the positional layer above gave those bands teeth.

Origin: what kind of power drives it

Every Trigger has one of four **origin** tags, describing what sort of energy is behind it:

- **Physical (23 Triggers):** raw body and weapon work.
- **Energy (11):** Trion channelled directly, elemental blasts and wards.
- **Afflict (6):** poison, venom, decay.
- **Mental (20):** psychic pressure and illusion.

Origin exists so that some abilities can shut down a whole *kind* of attack rather than a specific one. Seal of Severance locks a target out of one origin for 2 turns, which means every Trigger they own in that category becomes uncastable, and Foresight Counter works by naming an origin in advance and negating an attack that matches. Against those, a Loadout built entirely from one origin is fragile and a mixed one is resilient. This is a real reason to diversify.

Who a Trigger can be aimed at

Finally, each Trigger targets **an opponent** (51 of the 60), **an ally** (3), or **only its user** (6). Ally and self Triggers are the buffs, heals, wards, and the reactive counters you arm on your own turn.

Every single Trigger is listed with a plain description in Appendix A.

8. Full Arms Trigger (FAT): your burst turn

Normally a character uses **one ability per turn**. **Full Arms Trigger**, or **FAT**, is the exception that lets you go big.

- Each turn, a character has a chance (equal to its FAT Chance stat, boosted by a high Team Spirit) to **trigger FAT**.
- On a FAT turn, that character may use **up to 3 abilities** instead of 1.
- Going greedy has a price. If you use 2 or more abilities on the FAT turn, you pay a penalty: that character's cooldowns are **doubled** and its Trion Affinity is **halved**, and FAT then **locks out for 3 turns** before it can happen again.

FAT is your coordinated-nuke button, deliberately taxed so that spamming it hurts. It also interacts with counters: the Draegor counter specifically punishes an enemy who chains 2 or more abilities on a FAT turn.

9. How a turn works: queue then resolve

Turns **alternate** between the two squads. Who goes first at the very start of the battle is **weighted by the Team Efficiency Grade**: two squads on the same grade flip a fair coin, and every grade of separation shifts the odds by 5 points, up to 65/35 at three grades or more. Moving first in a game this lethal used to be pure luck, which was the one thing a player could not build toward; now the better-assembled squad is favoured for it, while the underdog still takes the opening turn better than one time in three. Going first is not free either: whoever moves first takes the lowest Trion income on that opening turn. On your turn each living character may either use an ability or **Reposition** one step (see section 7); a move counts against the same per-turn ability limit, so a FAT turn is what buys you both. Each team turn is capped at a **15-second timer** to lock in your actions; if it runs out the turn is forfeited with nothing committed. A Black Trigger's World ability can change that limit for its team, which is exactly what Chrono Fragment does.

On your turn:

1. **You queue actions.** For each living character you pick an ability and its targets, and it goes into your queue. The Trion cost is **spent the moment you queue it**, and if you change your mind and remove it from the queue, you get the Trion back. Cooldowns, on the other hand, only start once the action actually resolves.
2. **The game keeps you honest.** It only lets you queue legal actions (you can afford them, they are off cooldown, they have a valid target **inside their range band**, and you have not exceeded your per-turn ability limit, which is 1 normally or up to 3 on a FAT turn). Range is

measured from the position your queued moves will have put you in, so a step you have queued already counts. An ability you cannot use says why, and out of range says which band it needs.

3. **You end the turn.** Your queued actions now resolve in a set order (next section), the results are shown after a brief "Resolving..." pause, and then the AI takes its turn through the exact same process.

The AI builds and resolves a full queue the same way you do, which keeps single player and any future online play running on one shared system.

10. Resolution order: the six phases

When your turn resolves, your queued actions do **not** simply go in the order you picked them. They are sorted into a fixed **phase order** so that setups happen before payoffs. The phases are:

1. **Movement and setup:** every Reposition queued this turn, then arming counters and traps. Moves going first is what makes move-then-strike work, and it is why the queue judges range against where a character will be standing rather than where they are.
2. **Bufs** (boosting yourself or an ally, putting up wards).
3. **Control** (debuffs that do not deal damage, like stuns and slows).
4. **Attacks** (anything that deals damage).
5. Post-attack effects.
6. Cleanup, where timed effects tick down and expire.

Within a single phase, ties are broken by **how far a character's Team Spirit is from 50** (the more committed character goes first), and finally by the order you queued them. For example, a buff you queued second still resolves before an attack you queued first, because buffs are an earlier phase. And between two attacks, the character whose Team Spirit is furthest from 50 strikes first.

Approved and specced, not yet built: status reactions. Statuses will react to damage types and to each other, so applying one sets up the next. Wet plus a Cold hit becomes Frozen; Frozen plus a Bludgeoning hit shatters for double damage; Chilled plus Fire melts back to Wet; Scorched plus Cold is quenched to Chilled. Enraged is redesigned to grant immunity to Psychic damage at the cost of targeting at random, which makes it both a gamble on yourself and a control tool against someone else. The full table is in the status document.

A status effect is refreshed, not stacked. Applying an effect that is already on a character resets its timer rather than adding a second copy, and the longer of the two durations wins. So a character never carries the same effect twice, and never shows the same badge twice.

A friendly ability is granted, not inflicted. A heal, a ward or a buff aimed at yourself or an ally never rolls to hit and is never contested: it simply lands. Only an ability aimed at an enemy is contested, attacker's Status Effect Infliction against the target's Status Effect Resistance.

Traps do not inherit your buffs. A trap deals its own fixed damage when it fires, read off the trap rather than off whoever laid it, so being Empowered when it goes off changes nothing. It is a placed hazard, not an attack you are making.

When a status effect actually wears off. A timed effect ticks down at the **start of its holder's own turn**, and expires when the count reaches zero. Put that together with buffs resolving before attacks, and a status applied on a turn is live for the rest of that turn's resolution, stays live through the opponent's answer, and is decremented when its holder's next turn begins.

Two consequences worth stating plainly, because a bare turn count hides both:

- A buff lasting two turns or more is **still up on your next turn**, so a turn spent buffing sets up the attack you make next. That is the ordinary way a buff pays, and it needs no Full Arms Trigger. (Buffs also resolve before attacks within a turn, so on a FAT turn you can do both at once, but no ability is built to require that: an ability that only worked inside a FAT turn would mostly do nothing.)
- A **1-turn** effect is gone before its holder acts again. So the game says "active this turn only, it wears off when your next turn begins" rather than printing a 1, and a 2-turn effect says "active this turn and your next turn".

Known issue, awaiting the SPTV pass: because the tick happens at the start of the holder's turn, a 1-turn debuff placed on an enemy expires before that enemy acts, so it never affects the turn it was meant to interrupt. Eleven effects carry a 1-turn default, including Stunned and Frozen. The fix is a decision about when the tick happens, and it is priced with everything else in that pass.

11. How an attack is decided: the dice math

Every damaging hit is settled in two separate dice rolls: first a roll to see if it **hits**, then a completely separate roll for **how much damage** it does.

Step one, the to-hit roll. Both sides roll a 20-sided die.

- The attacker rolls their die and adds their Attack stat.
- The defender rolls their die and adds their Defense stat.
- If the attacker's total is greater than or equal to the defender's total, the attack **hits**. Otherwise it **misses**.
- Some perks and status effects grant **advantage** (roll two dice, keep the higher) or **disadvantage** (roll two, keep the lower). For instance, Airi Tanaka's perk Feint makes the first attacker against her roll with disadvantage.

Critical hits. A hit becomes a **critical hit** when the attacker's raw die lands in the critical range. With no Critical Chance you only crit on a natural 20; as Critical Chance climbs, the range widens, but only as far as a natural 17 even at the maximum, so the best possible crit build still crits on one roll in five. A critical hit **rolls the ability's damage dice a second time** (the flat damage bonus is not doubled). A **critical miss** (a very low roll) even penalizes the attacker, dropping their Defense and Team Spirit by 20% for one turn.

Step two, the damage roll. This is a fresh roll on the Trigger's own dice, and it passes through a short chain of adjustments (the battle log shows every step):

1. Start with the **dice total** (the Trigger rolls its dice, like two 6-sided dice plus a flat bonus).
2. Multiply by any **outgoing-damage bonus** from Team Spirit, perks, or statuses.
3. If it was a critical hit, roll the ability's damage dice again and add them (the flat bonus is not doubled).
4. Subtract the target's **Armor**.

5. Apply any **resistance or vulnerability** (a resisted damage type is halved; a status like Exposed increases it).
6. The result is the **final damage** dealt.

Burst abilities run this whole chain once per hit, and area abilities apply it to each target.

SPTV: the Status Point and Trigger Value budget

SPTV is the shorthand for the two-part pricing rule that keeps content honest, and it is used throughout these documents:

- **SP, Status Points**, prices an *effect*. How strong it is, multiplied by how long it lasts, multiplied by how many targets it hits. A stun costs more than a small attack penalty; two turns costs twice one turn; three targets cost three times one.
- **TV, Trigger Value**, prices a *whole ability*. It adds the damage and the SP together, divides by the Trion cost, and adjusts for cooldown, because an ability you can use every turn is worth more than the same one every third turn.

The two compose rather than compete: SP is an input to TV. Anything with a magnitude, a duration or a target count is in SPTV's scope, which includes the status effects, the Trigger costs and cooldowns, and the durations on the reactive counters and traps. Numbers that have not been through SPTV yet are first-pass values chosen by eye, and this document says so where that is true.

Damage types: what the damage is made of

Every damaging Trigger deals one of **13 damage types**, grouped into three categories:

Category	Damage types
Physical	Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing
Elemental	Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, Poison
Magical and utility	Force, Radiant, Necrotic, Psychic, Thunder

The type matters because of step 5 above. A character can be **resistant** to a type (they take half damage from it), or a status effect can make them **vulnerable** to it (they take extra) or outright **immune**. Wet, for example, makes a target immune to Fire but vulnerable to both Lightning and Cold, so soaking someone changes which of your abilities you should be reaching for. Scorched makes them vulnerable to Fire, Chilled to Cold, Corroded to Acid, and Sickened to four damage types picked at random. Resistances can also come from a character's own make-up or from equipment: Bastion Frame's Hardened Shell passive grants resistance to Bludgeoning.

The practical upshot is that a Loadout spread across several damage types is harder to wall off than one that leans on a single type, in the same way that a Loadout spread across several origins is harder to lock out.

How long a fight should last: 8 to 20 rounds. That is the pacing target the combat numbers are tuned against, and it is deliberately a band rather than a point. Eight rounds is a decisive engagement where one squad reads the matchup and closes it out; twenty is a grind between two well-assembled squads trading positions and status effects. A fight that ends much under eight means somebody was deleted before they got to play, and one that runs much over twenty

means nobody's damage is keeping up with the healing and the Trion. Both ends are balance bugs, and `tool/balance_report.dart` reports the distribution over 200 simulated battles so the band can be checked rather than assumed.

Design note: this is where the balance pass did most of its work. Attack and Defense used to run 10-29 and 6-16, which put a 15-point gap on a typical attack and meant the die changed almost nothing: attacks landed over 90% of the time and the roll was decoration. Attack now runs 4-14 and Defense 2-12, so the gap between any two characters fits inside the die's own range and the roll decides a real share of the outcome. Damage was rebuilt the same way: abilities used to be a small die on a huge flat bonus (2d6+37, 4d8+86), and are now roughly half dice (6d6+23, 6d8+29), so the damage roll swings too. Across 200 simulated AI-versus-AI battles this moved the average hit rate to about 50% and roughly doubled how long a fight lasts, which is what the reviews were asking for.

12. Status effects: the full list, explained

Status effects are temporary conditions you put on characters. There are 62 of them. Whether one sticks is a contest between the attacker's **Status Infliction** and the target's **Status Resistance** (some characters are simply immune to certain ones). Here is every status and exactly what it does. Durations are in turns.

Damage over time (they chip Health each turn)

- **Bleeding:** loses 8 Health each turn for 3 turns.
- **Poisoned:** loses Health each turn for 3 turns (a poison tick).
- **Scorched:** burning, loses 12 Health each turn for 2 turns.
- **Necrotic Wound:** rotting, loses 12 Health each turn for 3 turns.
- **Corroded:** Armor reduced by 3 for 2 turns (and pairs with acid attacks).
- **Acid:** Armor reduced by 5 for 3 turns.

Hard control (they stop the target acting)

- **Stunned:** cannot act for 1 turn.
- **Frozen:** frozen solid, cannot act for 1 turn.
- **Petrified:** turned to stone, cannot act for 2 turns, but takes only half damage while petrified.
- **Silenced:** cannot use abilities for 1 turn.
- **Charmed:** turned against their own team for 3 turns (a long, powerful loss of control).
- **Genjutsu Trapped:** caught in an illusion, cannot act, and loses 15% of Trion Capacity, for 1 turn.
- **Prone:** knocked down for 1 turn, easier to hit and hampered.
- **Shadow-Bound:** pinned in place by shadow for 2 turns.

Damage taken up or down

- **Marked:** takes +50% damage for 1 turn (a painter for a burst kill).
- **Exposed:** takes +25% damage for 2 turns.
- **Overwhelmed:** swamped and taking extra damage for 2 turns.
- **Guarded:** takes 25% less damage for 2 turns.
- **Braced:** braced for impact, reduced incoming damage for 3 turns.

- **Shattered Guard:** guard broken, defenses weakened for 2 turns.

Damage dealt up or down

- **Empowered:** deals +25% damage for 2 turns.
- **Enraged:** deals +50% damage but loses 3 Defense for 2 turns (reckless).
- **Weakened:** deals 25% less damage for 3 turns.

Stat changes

- **Inspired:** +2 Attack and +2 Defense for 2 turns.
- **Fatigued:** -2 Attack and -2 Defense for 3 turns.
- **Hastened:** Attack rises a little more each turn, for 2 turns.
- **Slowed:** Defense drops a little more each turn, for 2 turns.
- **Chilled:** Attack drops a little more each turn, for 2 turns.
- **Focused:** sharpened aim and readiness for 2 turns.
- **Blinded:** attacks are much less accurate for 2 turns.
- **Reeling:** knocked off balance for 3 turns.
- **Threatened:** pressured and softened up for 2 turns.
- **Terrified:** too afraid to fight effectively for 2 turns.
- **Cursed:** a lingering hex that worsens the target for 3 turns.

Crit and burst boosters

- **Adrenaline Rush:** +15 Critical Chance for 2 turns.
- **Battle Trance:** +20 FAT Chance for 2 turns.

Trion and status economy

- **Sapped:** loses 25% of Trion Capacity for 3 turns.
- **Overcharged:** your abilities cost half Trion for 2 turns.
- **Choked:** abilities cost double Trion for 2 turns.
- **Suppressed:** 5 less Status Infliction for 2 turns (worse at applying statuses).
- **Warded:** +10 Status Resistance for 2 turns (better at shrugging statuses).
- **Hexed:** 10 less Status Resistance for 2 turns (easier to afflict).
- **Sealed:** one ability type is sealed off for 2 turns.
- **Origin Lockout:** locked out of a category of Trigger for 2 turns.

Healing and protection

- **Regenerating:** heals a little Health each turn for 3 turns.
- **Radiant Blessing:** +10 Max Health, a small heal each turn, and slightly reduced incoming damage, for 3 turns.

Setup and disruption

- **Wet:** soaked, setting up bonus damage from lightning and cold follow-ups, 3 turns.
- **Sickened:** vulnerable to 4 random damage types (takes extra from them) for 3 turns.
- **Electrocuted:** shocked for 2 turns (chains strongly off Wet).
- **Prepared:** readied, boosting your next action, for 3 turns.
- **Misfire:** a 50% chance that each of your actions simply fails, for 2 turns.
- **Forced Repetition:** forced to repeat the same action for 2 turns.

- **Interdict:** branded so that repeating an ability lands at 25% strength, for 2 turns.
- **Forced Critical Miss:** your next attack is forced to be a critical miss.
- **Isolation:** cut off from ally support for 2 turns.
- **Untargetable:** cannot be targeted by anyone for 1 turn.
- **Echoing Doubt:** acting against this target backlashes onto you for 20 damage, for 1 turn.
- **Vow of the Duel:** two characters are bound in a duel: double damage passes between them, plus a 2-turn stun on the target.
- **Forced Choice:** forced into a lose-lose decision for 1 turn.
- **Karmic Bind:** a one-way link for 3 turns: whenever the caster takes damage or is healed, a Team-Spirit-scaled fraction of it is dealt to the bound enemy as unavoidable damage.
- **Called Shot:** one of the target's stats is reduced to zero for 2 turns.
- **Mind's Eye:** the target's hidden Loadout is revealed to you for 3 turns.

13. Counters: reacting to the enemy

Counters are how you react to the opponent instead of just acting. You arm them on your turn, and they fire automatically when the enemy does the right thing. There are two kinds.

Reactive counters (arm now, fire on the enemy's next action)

These come from special Triggers. Each does one specific thing:

- **Reflect:** bounces the next non-area attack straight back at whoever threw it.
- **Dodge Melee:** completely avoids the next single-target melee attack (this is the Predictive Parry Trigger).
- **Negate by Origin:** cancels the next attack that matches a chosen origin type.
- **Burst Mitigation:** cuts down incoming burst damage (the Numbing Toxin Trigger).
- **Cooldown Sabotage:** when the enemy attacks into it, their cooldowns get extended (the Frozen Tempo Trigger).
- **Redirect to Ally:** sends an incoming attack onto one of the attacker's own allies instead.
- **Trap on Action:** springs a trap the moment the target takes an action.
- **Nullify Area:** cancels an incoming area attack (the Death Ledger Trigger; the game then lets the holder borrow that nullified area ability into their own Loadout for 2 turns).
- **Bank Damage:** stores the damage you take and lets you release it later (the Stored Retribution Trigger).
- **Survive Lethal:** lets you live through a hit that would have knocked you out (the One More Breath ability).

Passive counters (they charge up, then discharge)

Six of them build up stacks based on what the enemy does, then unleash a big effect when full:

- **Draegor:** every ability its holder uses adds a stack of Enmity. At 5 stacks it becomes Regret for 2 turns. While Regret is up, if an enemy chains 2 or more abilities on a FAT turn, your squad's Team Efficiency Grade jumps 2 tiers for 2 turns (or, if you are already very high grade, your best Trion character's Affinity doubles instead). This can happen up to 3 times per battle.
- **Nullhymn:** builds a stack of Discord whenever an enemy uses a Black Trigger against you or lands a status on the holder. At 5 stacks it discharges (up to twice per battle): it permanently drops the enemy's most recently used Black Trigger one power grade, or, if no

enemy is running one, it purges your team's debuffs and reflects them back onto whoever applied the most.

- **Reckoning:** builds a stack of Debt whenever an enemy crits your team or uses a long-cooldown ability against it. At 6 stacks it comes due: the worst offender's cooldowns get extended, their next attack is forced to be a critical miss, and your team takes some of their Trion.
- **Gravehour:** at the end of an enemy turn, if they did no damage or left one of your enemies at 30% Health or lower, the holder gets a free, uncounterable finishing blow (40 flat damage) on the lowest-Health enemy, who also cannot be healed next turn. This has a 3-turn cooldown.
- **Coldread:** at the start of your turn it secretly marks an enemy. If that enemy then takes a damaging action, you earn a reward that alternates each time you read them correctly: first a Levy (steal the Trion from their costliest action), then a Seize (+2 to your whole squad's dice rolls for 1 turn). Guess wrong and your next Trion gain is docked.
- **Ironvow:** each turn a random attack type is "sanctioned" (never the same as last turn). If you attack with that type, you land a Sanctioned Strike that cannot be blocked, strips one of the target's buffs, and brands them (so repeating an ability against them two turns running lands weakened). The cost is that your other allies are left vulnerable to that type until your next turn. You get up to 3 of these per battle.

14. Unique abilities: the signature moves

The Unique-type characters and a handful of special Triggers have **unique abilities**, which are effects too special to describe as plain damage plus a status. There are 17 of them:

- **Shared Agony:** links two enemies together, so damage dealt to one also bleeds onto the other (at 1.2 times).
- **Grave Bargain:** you spend a quarter of your own current Health to power up a strike.
- **Martyr's End:** when you drop below 25% Health, you can detonate for 50 damage.
- **Vow of the Duel:** binds you and a target into a duel where double damage passes between you, and stuns them for 2 turns.
- **Sunder Arms:** a heavy single-target blow that shreds the target's armor.
- **Curving Shot:** a shot that curves past cover and defenses.
- **Called Shot:** a precise hit that reduces one of the target's stats to zero for a while.
- **Mind's Eye:** reveals a chosen enemy's full Loadout (and lets you click their abilities to read them) for 3 turns.
- **Forced Choice:** forces the target into a lose-lose decision.
- **Memory Theft:** steals or copies one of the target's abilities.
- **Sensory Swap:** swaps a targeting or sensory relationship between two targets.
- **Dread Resonance:** deals more damage the more total damage the target has already taken this battle (0.15 per point of prior damage, minimum 5).
- **Isolation:** cuts a target off from its allies' support.
- **Illusory Double:** you start with one decoy charge and gain more when an ally falls; the decoy soaks a hit meant for you.
- **Echoing Doubt:** plants a doubt so that acting against you backlashes for 20 damage.
- **Karmic Bind:** binds you to one enemy for 3 turns. It punishes rather than shares: every time *you* take damage or receive healing, a fraction of that amount lands on them as unavoidable damage. The fraction is set by your Team Spirit, from 25% at the low end to

60% at the high end, so a sustain-leaning caster turns their own healing into a weapon.

- **Unmaking:** a powerful unravelling debuff that strips the target down.

15. Combos: rewarding setups

The game watches what your squad does within a turn and recognizes **combos**, which are setup-then-payoff patterns. When it spots one, it rewards you (through the Team Efficiency Grade's combo bonuses: extra dice advantage on the payoff, and a Trion refund on the setup). There are 18 recognized combos in two layers.

Layer one, general patterns (they fire whenever the shape matches, no matter which specific abilities you used):

- **Control then Strike:** you control a target (a stun, freeze, and so on) and then attack it.
- **Affliction Detonate:** you attack a target that already has a damage-over-time or affliction on it.
- **Setup Exploit:** you exploit a debuff an ally already applied.
- **Focus Fire:** two or more of your characters hit the same target in one turn.

Layer two, signature chains (specific ability or status pairings, more thematic): Frozen Detonation, Terror Cascade, Shatterpoint Execution, Piercing Corrosion, Pinned Shot, Mind Unravel, Charmed Opening, Flashfire, Opening Sweep, Venom Reap, Snared Execution, Brittle Pierce, Blinding Volley, and Dread Shatter. Each of these looks for a particular first move that a particular second move then cashes in (for example, freezing a target and then shattering the ice, or blinding a group and then firing into it).

16. Team Efficiency Grade: your build score

Before the battle, the game scores each squad's three Loadouts into a **Team Efficiency Grade**, a letter grade that measures how well your team is built. It is not just a badge: it both helps you during the fight and controls how much XP you earn afterward, in opposite directions, so it is a genuine risk-reward choice.

How the grade is calculated. Six sub-scores are combined (weighted) into one number from 0 to 100, which maps to a tier:

- **Team Spirit Alignment (weighted most, 25%):** does each character's Loadout lean the same way their Team Spirit does (offense or sustain)? Committed teams score high.
- **Stat Coherence:** do a character's stats reinforce the job you are asking them to do?
- **Loadout Synergy:** do the equipped Triggers work well together?
- **Perk Utilization:** does the Loadout actually enable that character's perk?
- **Trion Economy:** do the costs of the build fit its income?
- **Resonance Fit:** how well the Black Trigger suits the character (this is blank if there is no Black Trigger).

The tiers, from worst to best: D, C, B, A, S, SS, SSS.

What the grade does in battle. A higher grade feeds a dice advantage into your attack, defense, and resistance rolls (a coordination bonus for you, and it also makes the enemy read you less well). At the very top (SSS) it widens your critical range. It also grants extra advantage on recognized combo payoffs and a Trion refund on combo setups. And the Draegor counter can temporarily shove your effective grade up 2 tiers.

What the grade does afterward. This is the clever part: a weaker grade earns **more** XP and a stronger grade earns **less**, so climbing the grade makes you better in the fight but slower to level up. The bonuses are:

Grade	D	C	B	A	S	SS	SSS
XP bonus	+75%	+63%	+51%	+40%	+28%	+16%	+5%

Your awarded XP is the base XP times (1 plus that bonus), rounded. It is computed on the server so it cannot be faked (see the Accounts section).

17. Black Triggers: the ultimate gear

A **Black Trigger** is a rare, powerful Loadout piece: effectively a whole extra kit bolted onto one character, usually a bundle of active abilities plus passive bonuses, and sometimes a once-per-battle "World ability." There are 10, and here is what each one gives you:

- **Ashbringer (attack):** three active abilities, Ashbringer Slash (a heavy melee hit), Ashbringer Volley (a ranged hit), and Seal of Severance. A well-rounded, short-cooldown damage package.
- **Fracture Edge (attack):** one active, Fracture Burst (a burst attack), plus the passive Sundering Focus that leans into offense.
- **Solar Flare (attack):** one active, Solar Flare, a single massive area nuke on a long cooldown, plus the passive Blazing Focus that boosts crits.
- **Aegis Core (defense):** a defensive World ability that negates the first few instances of damage you would take.
- **Bastion Frame (defense):** one active, Foresight Counter, plus three passives, Bastion Plating (armor), Hardened Shell (damage resistance), and Steady Mind (status resistance). A fortress package.
- **Wellspring (support):** two actives, Wellspring Surge (a direct heal) and Mirror Ward (a reflect), backing a sustain build.
- **Chorus Bond (support):** four passives, Bonded Resolve, Harmonic Focus, Warding Chorus, and Vital Chorus, all built around Team Spirit and team-wide healing.
- **Paradox Shard (unique):** four disruptive actives, Paradox Whisper, Paradox Fracture, Puppet Strings, and Deadfall, a bag of unpredictable debuffs and control.
- **Gravebind (unique):** one active, One More Breath, a World-style effect that lets you survive, once per battle, a hit that would otherwise defeat you.
- **Chrono Fragment (unique):** a World ability that adds 5 seconds to its wielder's team turn timer every turn. A tempo tool, not a combat one, and the cheapest Black Trigger to equip at 30.

Resonance: how well a Black Trigger suits its wielder

Any character may equip any Black Trigger. Nothing blocks a Support character from picking up an attack-type Black Trigger. What changes is **Resonance**: a grade from A down to D, set by comparing the character's own type against the Black Trigger's type.

Your character's type	Attack BT	Defense BT	Support BT	Unique BT
Attack	A	B	C	A
Defense	C	A	A	B
Support	D	A	A	B
Unique	B	B	B	B

The grade is a multiplier on everything that Black Trigger does: **A is 1.5x, B is 1.15x, C is 1.0x, and D is 0.85x**. It scales the Black Trigger's damage and healing, scales its passive and World-ability magnitudes, and divides its cooldowns, so a well-resonant Black Trigger both hits harder and comes back sooner.

A mismatch is legal, just inefficient. A Support character running an attack-type Black Trigger sits at D and gets a weaker version of it, which is a real build if you want it, just a costly one. Unique characters are the generalists: they get B with everything, never brilliant and never bad.

Resonance also feeds the Resonance Fit sub-score of the Team Efficiency Grade, and it is not permanent: the enemy's Nullhymn counter can knock your Black Trigger down a resonance grade for the rest of the battle.

18. Character perks: innate traits

Every character has one **perk** that is always active and that a good Loadout should try to make use of (the grade's Perk Utilization sub-score rewards this). Here is every perk and what it does:

Character (type)	Perk	What it does
Kaito Reyes (Attack)	Last Ace	His Critical Chance is doubled while he is the last living member of his team.
Vela Ashworth (Attack)	First Blood	Her first attack of the battle gains +25 Critical Chance , but only if the target is at full health.
Dross (Attack)	Overwhelm	His area attacks deal 25% more damage to a target that already has a status effect on it.
Ren Kobayashi (Attack)	First Strike	He gets +2 Attack on the first ability he uses each battle.
Airi Tanaka (Attack)	Feint	The first attack made against her each battle is rolled with disadvantage .
Marren Osei (Defense)	Bulwark	His Armor is doubled while any living teammate is below 25% health.
Ilona Vance (Defense)	Riposte	Whenever a melee attack against her misses, she gains a stacking +1 Attack buff for her next turn.
Bastian Cole (Defense)	Absorb	The first instance of damage he takes each battle is cut in half , on top of any other mitigation.
Dorian Voss (Defense)	Immovable	He is immune to anything that would reduce how many targets his ranged abilities can hit , so Blinded cannot narrow his area attacks.
Sable Whitlock (Defense)	Guardian's Instinct	Once per battle he can redirect an attack aimed at a living teammate onto himself instead.
Priya Nakamura (Support)	Combat Medic	Her heal-over-time effects heal for 30% more when applied to an ally below 50% health.
Soren Talvik (Support)	Weaken Resolve	Status effects he inflicts last 1 turn longer against a target already carrying one of his other debuffs.
Yuki Amaral (Support)	Devoted Aid	She receives 10% bonus healing from any source, including a drain Trigger that heals its user off someone else.
Haru Ellison (Support)	Battery	While she is alive, her team's Trion gain roll gets a positive modifier , making bigger income turns more likely.
Celestine Moreau (Support)	Warding Presence	Her ally-targeted buffs also grant that ally +5 Status Resistance .
Zheng Anders (Unique)	Foresight	Once per battle he can reroll one of his own missed attack rolls.
Nadia Kessler (Unique)	Chain Reaction	Each additional ability she uses on the same FAT turn deals 15% more than the last.
Rurik Voss (Unique)	All or Nothing	His outgoing damage rises as his own health falls , up to double at 0 health. Paired with the roster's highest Attack (14) and lowest Defense (2).
Mireille Song (Unique)	Decoy	Once per battle , an attack against her has a 35% chance to simply miss , as if she was never there.
Tobias Renner (Unique)	Versatile	He gets a small bonus to whichever stat matches the category of the ability he last used.

19. The AI opponent

In single player you fight an **AI profile**. The AI plans and resolves a full turn through the exact same system you do, with a short "thinking" pause before it commits, so the same rules apply to both sides. It also drafts its own Loadouts, using the same rules and budget you do.

There are **20 profiles**, built from two independent dials: a skill class that sets *how well* the profile plays, and a strategic identity that sets *what it is trying to do*.

Skill class controls execution. Every decision has a chance of being a "mistake", which means the AI falls back to a random legal choice instead of its intended one:

Skill class	Mistake chance	Weights Defense and resistances	Looks ahead
Beginner	40%	No	No
Amateur	25%	No	No
Intermediate	12%	Yes	No
Professional	5%	Yes	No
Expert	2%	Yes	Yes, predicts whether a hit would actually secure a kill

Strategic identity controls intent: who it targets, which ability it reaches for, when it chains FAT, whether it wants a Black Trigger, and what it drafts. There are four identities per skill class.

Beginner. **Button Masher** targets whoever is first in its list and fires whatever is off cooldown, with no evaluation at all. **The Turtle** hides behind self-buffs and passives to a fault and never chains FAT. **The Copycat** targets at random and simply mirrors whatever kind of move you used last. **The Berserker** chases raw damage with no target or resource discipline, fixating on whoever it last drew blood from.

Amateur. **The Sharpshooter** overvalues ranged and burst options even when something weaker would serve better. **The Healer's Crutch** over-prioritizes healing even when finishing a kill would end the fight sooner. **The Momentum Chaser** chains every FAT proc on principle, productive or not. **The Grudge Holder** fixates on whichever enemy has dealt it the most damage so far, regardless of who is nearly dead.

Intermediate. **The Executioner** piles the whole team onto one enemy until it dies, then retargets together. **The Afflictor** prioritizes landing statuses over raw damage. **The Blast Radius** reaches for area attacks whenever one is available, even against a single remaining target. **The Gambler** fires its Black Trigger the moment it can and equips one even when it resonates badly.

Professional. **The Tactician** has the Executioner's focus plus real judgment, weighing Defense and resistances rather than just health. **The Controller** sequences a debuff before committing to a burst, so the setup buys something. **The Sweeper** focus-fires by default and only switches to area attacks once two or more enemies are actually in kill range together. **The Economist** spends extra FAT actions only for a kill or a clear tempo swing.

Expert. **The Grandmaster** runs full lookahead, predicting whether a hit actually secures a kill before committing. **The Silent Blade** opens with debuff setup then unloads a maximized burst with near-perfect FAT timing. **The Wall** grinds you down with World abilities and stacked passives before turning aggressive. **The Prodigy** re-reads the board on every single ability choice rather than committing to one plan, which is the closest thing to a skilled human opponent.

Teaching the AI to value the counters, uniques, and status effects well is still a planned task: it plays the core game properly but does not yet appreciate the newer systems.

20. Accounts and XP: the online part

Accounts and XP run on a real online backend (Supabase), with a safety net that falls back to a local-only mode if the backend is ever unreachable, so the game always runs.

- **Signing in is stress-free.** You can play instantly as a **guest** (no sign-up at all), or use **passwordless email** (you get a magic link, nothing to remember), or **Google**. If you start as a guest and later sign in, you keep the same account and all your progress.
 - **XP is calculated on the server, so it cannot be cheated.** When a battle ends, your app reports the result, and the server recalculates the grade-based XP itself and updates your total. A player can never just set their own XP. The database also makes sure each player can only ever see and change their own data.
 - A small daily automated task keeps the free online project awake so it is always available.
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21. What is built so far

- **The battle engine is complete:** the queue-and-resolve turn system, all the reactive and passive counters, the unique abilities, the rebalanced Trigger catalog, combo recognition, and the Team Efficiency Grade with its in-battle effects and inverse XP.
- **Accounts and XP are live** and verified end to end.
- **The interface** has the grade badge, all stats shown, the Team Spirit readout, the Loadout builder, plain-language descriptions of the passive counters, the clickable character and enemy detail panels with the Mind's Eye reveal, the sign-in flow, the post-battle XP screen, the full-width battlefield strip with its distance ruler and move controls, and the rebuilt battle log (tap any line for a plain-English breakdown, and tap names or abilities to read them). Still to come: showing the pending queue during a turn, and polishing the resolve pause.
- **Balance:** most of the pass is done. The five near-duplicate Trigger pairs have distinct identities. Critical hits are capped at a natural 17 and double only the damage dice. The four Triggers that dominated the catalog (Whirlwind Slash, Twin Fang Strike, Longshot, Cinderburst) are re-costed. Bounded accuracy is restored: Attack runs 4-14 and Defense 2-12, and every damage expression is about half dice, so the 20-sided die decides a real share of every attack. The opening turn is earned rather than flipped for, weighted by the Team Efficiency Grade. And the range tag became three real bands, Close, Mid and Long, 20 Triggers each, with every attack type present in every band.

- **The spatial pillar is built.** Front, Middle and Back are real positions, distance is measured across the gap, every band reaches its own window of it, and Reposition costs a character their action. Range is enforced both at queue time (judged from where a queued move will put you) and again at resolution. See section 7.
- **Screening is built.** Standing behind a teammate now puts real distance between you and the enemy, Close Range reaches 0 to 2 against an enemy, and breaking a screen is how you get at the people behind it. See section 7.
- **Still to come on balance:** pull and push effects; a "Bail Out" downed state instead of instant defeat; explicit points budgets for status effects and Triggers; more traps built around position; and a steadier Trion economy. All of it is designed and approved, and the running order is in [current_development_status.md](#).

Appendix A: Every Trigger, explained

Each entry lists the cost in Trion, the cooldown in turns, and a plain description. There are 60 active Triggers.

Attacker Triggers (melee bruisers) (16)

- **"Martyr's End"** (costs 10 Trion, 4-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: detonates for 50 damage when you are below 25% Health.
- **Cinderburst** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A close-range area fire attack dealing about 15 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Scorched (12 burn damage per turn).
- **Cleave** (costs 15 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A close-range area slashing attack dealing about 22 damage to each of up to 2 enemies. Applies Shattered Guard (guard broken, weaker defense).
- **Cryo Burst** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area cold attack dealing about 18 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Chilled (attack sinks each turn).
- **Dread Resonance** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: hits harder the more damage the target has taken.
- **Dread Wave** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area psychic attack dealing about 16 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Overwhelmed (swamped, takes extra damage).
- **Frost Lance** (costs 14 Trion, 1-turn cooldown). A mid-range single-target cold attack dealing about 22 damage. Applies Chilled (attack sinks each turn).
- **Grave Bargain** (costs 8 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: spends 25% of your own Health to power the strike.
- **Piercing Thrust** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range single-target piercing attack dealing about 52 damage.
- **Predictive Parry** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A self-targeted setup or counter (no direct damage). Counter: dodges the next single-target melee attack.
- **Shared Agony** (costs 14 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range unique necrotic attack dealing about 47 damage. Signature effect: links two enemies so damage bleeds between them.
- **Soul Siphon** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A close-range single-target psychic attack dealing about 22 damage.
- **Sunder Arms** (costs 16 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A close-range unique slashing attack dealing about 37 damage. Signature effect: shreds the target armor.

- **Twin Fang Strike** (costs 15 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A close-range single-target slashing attack dealing about 44 damage.
- **Vow of the Duel** (costs 15 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: binds a duel: double damage between you plus a 2-turn stun.
- **Whirlwind Slash** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A close-range area slashing attack dealing about 17 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Bleeding (8 damage per turn).

Shooter Triggers (ranged volume) (9)

- **Arc Volley** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range rapid burst lightning attack dealing about 10 damage per hit across 3 hits on each of up to 2 targets.
- **Frag Grenade** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area piercing attack dealing about 20 damage to each of up to 3 enemies.
- **Gatling Burst** (costs 24 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range rapid burst piercing attack dealing about 10 damage per hit across 5 hits. Applies Exposed (takes +25% damage).
- **Pepper Shot** (costs 16 Trion, 1-turn cooldown). A close-range rapid burst piercing attack dealing about 10 damage per hit across 3 hits.
- **Rapid Fire** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range rapid burst piercing attack dealing about 17 damage per hit across 3 hits. Applies Bleeding (8 damage per turn).
- **Scattershot** (costs 22 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A close-range rapid burst piercing attack dealing about 6 damage per hit across 4 hits on each of up to 3 targets. Applies Slowed (defense sinks each turn).
- **Split Shot** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range rapid burst piercing attack dealing about 14 damage per hit across 2 hits on each of up to 2 targets.
- **Suppressing Fire** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range rapid burst piercing attack dealing about 10 damage per hit across 3 hits on each of up to 2 targets. Applies Suppressed (worse at applying statuses).
- **Thunderclap Round** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area thunder attack dealing about 13 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Overwhelmed (swamped, takes extra damage).

Sniper Triggers (long-range big hits) (3)

- **Called Shot** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: zeroes one of the target stats.
- **Curving Shot** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range unique piercing attack dealing about 37 damage. Signature effect: curves past cover and defense.
- **Longshot** (costs 24 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range single-target piercing attack dealing about 56 damage.

Trapper Triggers (control and debuffs) (24)

- **Acid Spray** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range area acid attack dealing about 13 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Corroded (-3 armor).
- **Caustic Cloud** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area acid attack dealing about 9 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Poisoned (damage each turn).
- **Charm Whisper** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Applies Charmed (turned against their team).
- **Death Ledger** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range single-target piercing attack dealing about 10 damage. Counter: nullifies an incoming area attack.

- **Dread Gaze** (costs 14 Trion, 1-turn cooldown). A mid-range single-target psychic attack dealing about 10 damage. Applies Terrified (too afraid to fight well).
- **Echoing Doubt** (costs 16 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: backlashes for 20 if acted against.
- **Flashbang Round** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Applies Blinded (much less accurate).
- **Forced Choice** (costs 14 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: forces a lose-lose choice.
- **Isolation** (costs 14 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: cuts the target off from allies.
- **Karmic Bind** (costs 16 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: damage you take or healing you receive is passed on to the bound enemy, scaled by Team Spirit.
- **Mass Confusion** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area psychic attack dealing about 10 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Silenced (cannot use abilities).
- **Memory Theft** (costs 16 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: steals or copies an ability.
- **Mind Fog** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area psychic attack dealing about 10 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Blinded (much less accurate).
- **Mind Shatter** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range single-target psychic attack dealing about 10 damage. Applies Silenced (cannot use abilities).
- **Nightmare Pulse** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area psychic attack dealing about 14 damage to each of up to 2 enemies. Applies Terrified (too afraid to fight well).
- **Numbing Toxin** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A self-targeted setup or counter (no direct damage). Counter: reduces incoming burst damage.
- **Psychic Scream** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A long-range area psychic attack dealing about 10 damage to each of up to 3 enemies. Applies Silenced (cannot use abilities).
- **Root Snare** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range single-target bludgeoning attack dealing about 10 damage. Applies Forced Repetition (stuck repeating an action).
- **Scramble** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A mid-range single-target psychic attack dealing about 10 damage. Applies Misfire (50% chance actions fail).
- **Sensory Swap** (costs 14 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: swaps a targeting link between two enemies.
- **Shatterpoint** (costs 12 Trion, 1-turn cooldown). A close-range single-target acid attack dealing about 22 damage. Applies Corroded (-3 armor).
- **Unmaking** (costs 18 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: a heavy unravelling debuff.
- **Venom Needle** (costs 12 Trion, 1-turn cooldown). A mid-range single-target poison attack dealing about 15 damage. Applies Poisoned (damage each turn).
- **Venom Spray** (costs 20 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A close-range rapid burst poison attack dealing about 9 damage per hit across 3 hits on each of up to 2 targets. Applies Poisoned (damage each turn).

Optional Triggers (buffs, wards, counters) (8)

- **"Guardian's Aegis"** (costs 14 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A self-targeted setup or counter (no direct damage). Applies Guarded (takes 25% less damage). Applies Braced (reduced incoming damage).
- **"Mind's Eye"** (costs 10 Trion, 3-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: reveals the enemy Loadout for 3 turns.
- **Cleansing Ward** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Applies Regenerating (heals each turn). Applies Warded (+resistance).
- **Frozen Tempo** (costs 18 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A self-targeted setup or counter (no direct damage). Counter: extends the attacker cooldowns when they hit it.
- **Illusory Double** (costs 0 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Signature effect: a decoy that soaks a hit.
- **Rally Cry** (costs 14 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A utility ability (no direct damage). Applies Inspired (+2 attack and defense).
- **Stored Retribution** (costs 16 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A self-targeted setup or counter (no direct damage). Counter: banks damage taken to release later.
- **War Chant** (costs 10 Trion, 2-turn cooldown). A self-targeted setup or counter (no direct damage). Applies Empowered (deals +25% damage).

Appendix B: The full character roster (20)

Character	Type	Attack	Defense	Armor	Health	Trion Cap	Trion Aff	Team Spirit	Crit	FAT	Perk
Kaito Reyes	attack	13	4	1	100	110	20	35	15	12	Last Ace
Vela Ashworth	attack	12	3	1	100	105	18	40	12	10	First Blood
Dross	attack	11	5	2	100	115	16	35	6	9	Overwhelm
Ren Kobayashi	attack	12	4	1	100	100	22	30	10	14	First Strike
Airi Tanaka	attack	10	5	1	100	100	20	45	13	11	Feint
Marren Osei	defense	5	12	3	100	120	16	55	3	7	Bulwark
Ilona Vance	defense	8	11	2	100	110	18	50	5	8	Riposte
Bastian Cole	defense	6	10	3	100	115	16	50	3	7	Absorb
Dorian Voss	defense	7	10	2	100	110	18	48	4	8	Immovable
Sable Whitlock	defense	6	11	3	100	115	18	55	4	8	-
Priya Nakamura	support	4	6	1	100	105	24	65	4	9	Combat Medic
Soren Talvik	support	5	5	1	100	105	20	60	5	9	Weaken Resolve
Yuki Amaral	support	4	7	2	100	105	22	70	4	8	Devoted Aid
Haru Ellison	support	4	6	1	100	130	32	60	4	9	Battery
Celestine Moreau	support	4	7	2	100	110	20	62	4	8	Warding Presence
Zheng Anders	unique	9	6	1	100	105	24	45	8	12	Foresight
Nadia Kessler	unique	10	5	1	100	100	20	40	9	16	Chain Reaction
Rurik Voss	unique	14	2	1	100	100	18	30	14	13	All or Nothing
Mireille Song	unique	9	5	1	100	100	20	45	8	11	Decoy
Tobias Renner	unique	9	6	1	100	105	20	45	7	11	Versatile

Appendix C: Status effect magnitudes

Damage and armor

Setting	Value
bleedingDamagePerTurn	8
scorchedDamagePerTurn	12
necroticWoundDamagePerTurn	12
acidArmorReduction	5
corrodedArmorReduction	3

Damage multipliers

Setting	Value
markedAllDamageTakenMultiplier	1.5
exposedAllDamageTakenMultiplier	1.25
guardedAllDamageTakenMultiplier	0.75
petrifiedAllDamageTakenMultiplier	0.5
empoweredOutgoingDamageMultiplier	1.25
enragedOutgoingDamageMultiplier	1.5
weakenedOutgoingDamageMultiplier	0.75

Trion, crit, and other

Setting	Value
sappedDrainPercentOfTrionCapacity	0.25
genjutsuTrappedDrainPercentOfTrionCapacity	0.15
adrenalineRushCriticalChanceBonus	15
battleTranceFatChanceBonus	20

Appendix D: All the tunable numbers

Trion income

Setting	Value
baseChanceLowToMedium	0.35
baseChanceMediumToHigh	0.20
affinityWeightPerPoint	0.01
lowAmount	10
mediumAmount	20
highAmount	35

Full Arms Trigger

Setting	Value
baseFatCooldownTurns	3
maxAbilitiesOnFatTrigger	3
normalAbilitiesPerTurn	1
multiAbilityPenaltyThreshold	2
cooldownDoubleMultiplier	2.0
trionAffinityPenaltyMultiplier	0.5

Combat and crit

Setting	Value
criticalHitDamageMultiplier	2.0
criticalMissDefensePenaltyPct	0.20
criticalMissTeamSpiritPenaltyPct	0.20
thresholdAtMinChance	20
thresholdAtMaxChance	17
minChancePercent	0
maxChancePercent	90

Loadout and Team Spirit

Setting	Value
maxEquippedTriggers	8
requiredActiveAbilityCount	4
statMin	0
statMax	100
midpoint	50
maxSingleTargetDamageBonus	0.30
maxBurstDamageBonus	0.30
maxCriticalChanceBonus	20
maxHealthRegenBonus	0.30
maxFatChanceBonus	20
secondsPerTurn	15}}

Passive counters

Setting	Value
draegorEnmityThreshold	5
draegorMaxRegretPerBattle	3
nullhymnDiscordThreshold	5
nullhymnMaxDischarges	2
reckoningDebtThreshold	6
gravehourFinisherFlatDamage	40
gravehourLowHpThreshold	0.3
coldreadSeizeRollBonus	2
ironvowMaxSanctionedStrikes	3

Unique abilities

Setting	Value
sharedAgonyLinkedDamageMultiplier	1.2
graveBargainHpSpendFraction	0.25
martyrsEndHpThreshold	0.25
martyrsEndDamage	50
dreadResonanceDamagePerCumulativeDamage	0.15
dreadResonanceMinDamage	5
illusoryDoubleStartingCharges	1
echoingDoubtBacklashDamage	20
vowOfTheDuelDamageMultiplier	2.0
vowOfTheDuelStunDurationTurns	2

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